

and could not pull the plow.

"‘Then,’ said the farmer, ‘hitch the ass to the plow for the plowing must go on.’

"All that day the ass, who had only intended to help his friend, found himself compelled to do the ox’s task. When night came and he was released from the plow his heart was bitter and his legs were weary and his neck was sore where the bow had chafed it.

"The farmer lingered in the barnyard to listen.

"The ox began first. ‘You are my good friend. Because of your wise advice I have enjoyed a day of rest.’

"‘And I,’ retorted the ass, ‘am like many another simple-hearted one who starts to help a friend and ends up by doing his task for him. Hereafter you draw your own plow, for I did hear the master tell the slave to send for the butcher were you sick again. I wish he would, for you are a lazy fellow.’ Thereafter they spoke to each other no more—this ended their friendship. Canst thou tell the moral to this tale, Rodan?"

"‘Tis a good tale," responded Rodan, "but I see not the moral."

"I thought not that you would. But it is there and simple too. Just this: If thou desire to help thy friend, do so in a way that will not bring thy friend’s burdens upon thyself."

"I had not thought of that. It is a wise moral. I wish not to assume the burdens of my sister’s husband. But tell me. You lend to many. Do not the borrowers repay?"

Mathon smiled the smile of one whose soul is rich with much experience. "Could a loan be well made if the borrower cannot repay? Must not the lender be wise and judge carefully whether his gold can perform a useful purpose to the borrower and return to him once more; or whether it will be wasted by one unable to use it wisely and leave him without his treasure, and leave the borrower with a debt he cannot repay? I will show to thee the tokens in my token chest and let them tell thee some of their stories."

Into the room he brought a chest as long as his arm covered